



May 2026
50th Year of Growth
1976 - 2026



Contact Email: doncastergardenclubinc@gmail.com

Web Address: www.doncastergardenclubaus.com

The DGC committee meeting was held on 6 May 2026 at 7.30 pm.

The next DGC meeting will be held on **Wednesday, 13 May 2026**
7.30 pm at the RSL Hall , cnr Doncaster Road and Leeds Street. Doors open at 7.15pm

The speaker is Paul Davies, Director Heathmont Honey

Committee Members 2026

President

Avril Clark

0402 478 302

doncastergardenclubinc@gmail.com

Vice-President & Speaker

Bookings:

Vacant

Treasurer:

Dr Margaret Salter

Secretary:

Virgina Roberts & Connie Lee

secretary@doncastergardenclubaus.com

Fund Raising Co-Ordinator:

Anita Lizza

Newsletter:

Rohini Padey

newseditor@doncastergardenclubaus.com

Reinhard

Esther Sim

Ray Brett

President's message May 2026

We are sad to announce that one of our Life members - Vale Ken Beer passed away recently. Ken was born in Bendigo and was the eldest of 12 children. He moved to Melbourne with his family for work and settled in Doncaster East. Ken joined Doncaster Garden Club at the second meeting and has been associated with the Club from its inception

He always loved growing vegetables and flowers and ran a Nandina nursery as a sideline. He served on the Garden Club Committee for many years and was always very encouraging to new members.

He won the S.S.McKay memorial medal from the Royal Horticultural Society of Victoria as well as the prestigious Gold John Pascoe Fawcner medal for outstanding service to Horticulture in 2006 and became a Life Member of the Doncaster Garden Club. Lately he became profoundly deaf and was not able to come to Club meetings any more.

Those of us who knew him remember his enthusiasm and friendship with great affection.

A picture of Ken with his award.



Avril

Speaker for April - Craig Castree on Companion planting

Craig Castree spoke about companion planting and how to implement it. He gave us examples from his garden and what has worked over the years.

He noted that some of the functions of companion planting include attracting beneficial insects and pollinators, increasing biodiversity and improving resilience against pest outbreaks and diseases, improved flavour and weed suppression. Some classic companion planting combinations including "the three sisters" of corn (support), beans (fix nitrogen into the soil) and squash (acts as a living mulch to retain moisture and suppress weeds); tomato and basil (basil helps to deter pests and improve flavour). One tip that he shared is that he plants marigolds and lavender in pots so he can move them around his garden to deal with pests. What a great idea!!

Craig emphasized that we should move away from growing vegetables in straight monoculture rows or close together. This is what has eroded the soil and we should fix it so we can stop using fertilisers and the soil repairs itself. Craig showed photos of his garden where he has mixed vegetables, herbs, flowers and fruit trees together.

His catch phrase "what goes well on the plate together, goes well in the garden together". He grows tomatoes, basil and garlic together, rhubarb and apple, and Asian greens and garlic. Some of the flowering plants in Craig's garden included alyssum, nasturtium, lavender, marigold and sunflower. Sunflowers form a highly beneficial symbiotic relationship with mycorrhizal fungi and improve soil health. He noted that carrot flowers attract many beneficial insects.

He has beans and peas in different areas of his garden. These nitrogen-fixing plants help feed soil biology and support heavy-feeding vegetables nearby.

To deter sap-sucking insects like aphids and whiteflies, Craig plants strong-scented herbs and flowers such as marigolds, garlic, chives, basil, lavender and nasturtiums. Craig surrounds his brassicas with many different plants including white violas and aromatic herbs (rosemary, thyme and sage). These strongly scented herbs may help mask brassica scent from pests such as cabbage moths. The white butterfly is very territorial and will stay away from white violas.

He plants chives and nasturtiums under apple trees to deter codling moths.

It was a great talk with lots of ideas on what we can implement in our gardens. Thanks.

Ryset Order

As requested by a few members we will place a Ryset order again in the month of June. Please pick up your form at the next Club meeting and send it to Avril at avril@spiritofprogress.com.au.

Beetroot, broccoli, leeks, peas, Peruvian cucumber, & garlic from Pauline's garden



Upcoming calendar events:

Upcoming Committee Meeting:	06 May	hosted by Avril Clark, 7.30pm at 62 Pine Hill Drive Doncaster East
Upcoming Meeting:	13 May	at the RSL Hall, 7.30pm at cnr Doncaster Road and Leeds Street Doncaster East

Following Committee Meeting:	03 June	hosted by Avril Clark, 7.30pm at 62 Pine Hill Drive Doncaster East
Following Meeting:	10 June	at the RSL Hall, 7.30pm at cnr Doncaster Road and Leeds Street Doncaster East

The speaker at the next meeting in June will be Rachel Maggiore who will talk about Pruning Roses

Hello Gardeners All

Many days of April were 7deg above average so I feel the birds seen mating last month will have managed to successfully hatch chick's. The current rain will increase insect supplies to eat.

With only 45mm of rain for April it was a tough month for growing water hungry vegetables. The wicking beds for some of them saved much work as they only needed filling once. The raised beds were a different story and were watered twice weekly when there was no rain. 10mm is considered sufficient not to need to water.

The skirret, yacon and pumpkins are dying off so, soon I will check out the size of the underground roots - except for the pumpkins of course which are in plain sight and ripening slowly. Two may only half ripen as they are so green but will still be edible as are all parts of the pumpkin vine when young.

I am picking chokos. Not a heavy crop as the heat destroyed some of the vine but enough for the household. I've sliced and shredded two jars full to ferment for later eating. The oca (NZ yams) are commencing to grow bulbs. The bushes look scruffy after partly dying back in the extreme heat. I'm not sure what size the root bulbs will be when they die back in June or July. I must top dress them with compost. The sweet potato survived the heat well but they too need to die back in June to discover the quantity of roots. If they are few, the water was insufficient.

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Some self sown potatoes have been fertilised and mulched with sugar cane mulch and I have other potatoes to plant soon. Last winter gave me enough crop to warrant growing them but I have left it late to plant. The carrot seeds are two cm high, the white garlic is about 150mm high and the red striped one is 60cm. Both look good.

The broccoli is at half height and looking healthier now it is netted from aphids and whitefly. There is a spray available called Potassium Salts of Fatty Acids which deals with both insects. It claims to be organic. I have asked another knowledgeable Gardener what he knows about it before I possibly buy it but am still needing a response. As the rats or possums ate the lettuce and bok choy seedlings the night after planting them, I have more seeds planted.

The garden is providing silverbeet, Malabar spinach, amaranth leaf, basil, rosemary, sweet marjoram, 1/2 ripe pumpkin (the vine died out completely), figs, persimmons, strawberries, raspberries, Peruvian cucumbers and chokos. All taste better for being grown without petroleum based fertilisers or sprayed with poisons.

Happy Gardening Pauline

From my Bookshelf May 2026

The Plant Hunters. Toby Musgrave, Chris Gardner, Will Musgrave. Ward Lock 1999

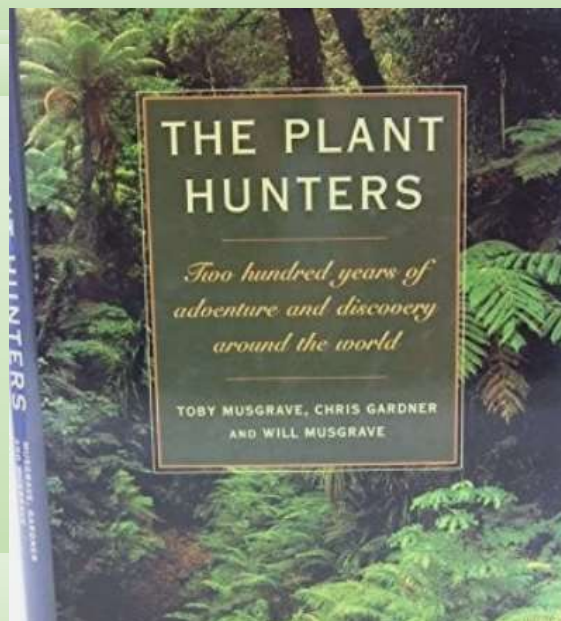
The great explorations, which began in the Fifteenth century and continued to the Nineteenth century, brought back unimaginable riches in the form of exquisite materials, spices, herbs, plants to name but a few

This book covers the Seventeenth to the Nineteenth centuries and so many of the plants that we love and grow today were brought back by plant hunters, some in the most difficult circumstances and some even losing their lives in the process. This book assesses the contributions of Sir Joseph Banks, Francis Masson, David Douglas, Sir Joseph Dalton Hooker, Robert Fortune, The Lobbs and Veitch dynasty, Ernest Wilson, George Forrest and Frank Kingdon-Ward.

Many names will be familiar to you but I want to draw your attention to two in particular. The Scot David Douglas (1799-1834) explored large tracts of Canada and East and West coasts of America. The going was not always easy but despite this he collected a huge array of seeds and many of his major discoveries were conifers. It was from his considerable collection and documentation of these that Charles Weston drew upon for use in Canberra.

Ernest Wilson (1876-1930) spent almost all of his years of exploration in China and then Japan bringing back beautiful Rhododendrons, Azaleas and lilies to name but a few. Another interesting connection to Australia was that he supplied the famous Dandenong Nursery run by George Woolrich (now Cloudehill) with beautiful Rhododendrons some of which still survive today.

The stories of these plant hunters are fascinating and shows the extraordinary resilience and passion of these men in sometimes life threatening conditions.

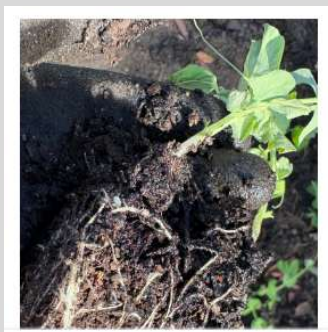


How to fix water hydrophobic soil (by Robin Gale-Baker) - Article courtesy LFC

A quick solution is to use 2 drops (no more) of washing up detergent per 9 litre watering can of water and thoroughly wet the surface. Just as detergent breaks down grease when washing dishes, it also breaks down the waxy covering of soil particles. Use a plant based detergent to avoid putting petroleum derivatives on your soil. You may need to repeat the procedure several times over several days.

To check your pots for moisture turn them upside down, gently tap the rim on a hard surface, slide the plant out and examine the root ball. If it is dry, soak it in a tray of water or dunk it for 10 minutes in a bucket of water before returning it to the pot.

check details on - <https://localfoodconnect.org.au/>



What seeds to plant in May

Here is a list of which seeds to plant. There are detailed planiting guides on LFC which you can refer to, see link below.

Brassicas	Cool season veggies	Leafy greens	Other
Kale	Broad beans	Lettuce	Carrot
	Coriander	Rocket	Chickpea
Mizuna	Fennel	Silverbeet	Chives
Mustard greens	Garlic	Spinach	Onion
Pak choy / box choy			Parsley
			Radish

If you haven't planted your cool season veggie seeds yet, plant them now. It's now a bit late for planting broccoli, cabbage and cauliflower seeds (but it's ok to plant seedlings).

<https://localfoodconnect.org.au/>

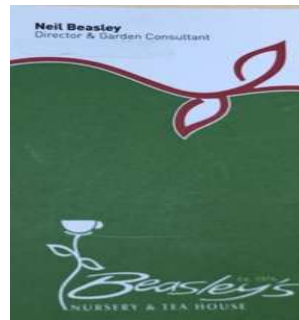
DGC Life Members	
Gerda van der Peet Doug Brewer Toni Myers Gayle McCann	Ted Page Joanne Driver Elsie Carter Bev Turner Franziska Kung

Doncaster Garden Club Inc. Membership 2026

Annual fees are due every October, those who have not paid for 2026 please do so at your earliest

Please complete the membership form on the Clubs website:
<https://doncastergardenclubaus.com/becomeamember>

Newsletters are emailed every month. For those wishing a hard-copy, please provide a self-



The Catalogue can be found online : <https://ryset.com>
The Club receives wholesale prices which means discounts of up to 60-70%

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